

Secretary

FF16 Customer service and administration · ISCO-08 4120 · CBS 0432 Secretariele medewerkers · seniority medior · Also known as: Administrative secretary

Supports a department or manager with diary management, correspondence, minute taking and the organisation of meetings and visits.

The secretary works closely with one or a few managers and must handle confidential information carefully. The distinction from an administrative employee lies in direct support of a person or team rather than general administration. Selection often fails on candidates who are organisationally strong but show insufficient discretion in handling sensitive information.

Key figures for this profile

22 skills · 4 competencies to measure · 4 knockout skills · centre of gravity: Communication and influence 36%, Digital, data and AI 21%, Self-management, drive and resilience 14%

1 Competencies to measure

These are the behavioural and ability constructs in this profile. Each one shows which hrmforce questionnaire measures it.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Client focus Competency (50-framework): Klantgerichtheid Knockout	 N4	Big Fifty, Competency Check, 360 Feedback	360 feedback	Uncovers the real need behind a client question, makes a fitting proposal and checks after delivery whether it works.

Competencies to measure	Target level	hrmforce instrument	Assessment method	Behavioural anchor at target level
Accuracy and attention to detail Competency (50-framework): Nauwkeurigheid Knockout		Big Fifty, 360 Feedback	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Builds check moments into the own process, keeps track of errors and prevents repetition by adjusting the method.
Stress tolerance Competency (50-framework): Stressbestendigheid		Big Fifty, 15PF, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.
Switching between tasks and roles Competency (50-framework): Flexibiliteit		Big Fifty, Kleurenprofiel (Jung), Competency Check	Praktijkobservatie	Switches independently between execution and consultation tasks, keeps notes per role and correctly resumes interrupted work.

2 Full skill profile

Every skill in this profile, sorted by weight. The behavioural anchor under each skill belongs to the target level.

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
G	Client focus Uncovers the real need behind a client question, makes a fitting proposal and checks after delivery whether it works.	 N4	5	yes	360 feedback	Big Fifty, Competency Check, 360 Feedback
G	Accuracy and attention to detail Builds check moments into the own process, keeps track of errors and prevents repetition by adjusting the method.	 N3	5	yes	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 360 Feedback
V	Working with digital devices and applications Selects the appropriate device and application for each task and fixes common disruptions without support from others.	 N3	5	yes	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Time management and prioritising Ranks own work by urgency and importance, builds in buffer time and explains to others why an item will arrive later.	 N4	4	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, 360 Feedback
T	Word processing and document management Builds documents using styles, references and a table of contents and keeps versions and folder structure orderly for the team.	 N4	4	no	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef
K	Dutch language proficiency at professional level Writes and discusses professional documents fluently at level B2 and adapts register to formal and informal situations.	 N3	4	yes	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Complaint handling Calms an angry client, separates emotion from facts and offers a solution with a deadline within own mandate.	 N3	4	no	Situational Judgement Test	Conflictstijlen, Werkproef
V	Service calls and telephone contact Settles unusual questions within a single call, keeps call time under control and audibly summarises the agreement made.	 N3	4	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Communicatiestijlen
V	Written client communication Writes a tailored reply in plain language, explains a rejection and offers an alternative course of action.	 N3	4	no	Werkproef	Werkproef
G	Stress tolerance Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.	 N3	4	no	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	Big Fifty, 15PF, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Information gathering and filtering Chooses sources independently for an open question, filters out duplicate and outdated data and justifies that choice.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Competency Check, Werkproef
V	Correspondence and record keeping Formulates answers to unusual questions independently, records the considerations briefly and keeps the file complete and up to date.	 N3	3	no	Werkproef	Werkproef
V	Expectation management Records at the start what falls outside the assignment and discusses deviations with the client before they become visible.	 N3	3	no	Structureerd interview	Competency Check, Structureerd interview

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	de-escalating and setting limits States which limit is being crossed when behaviour is unwanted, what the consequence is, and ends the conversation when needed.	 N3	3	no	Situational Judgement Test	Conflictstijlen, Big Fifty, Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)
G	Switching between tasks and roles Switches independently between execution and consultation tasks, keeps notes per role and correctly resumes interrupted work.	 N3	3	no	Praktijkobservatie	Big Fifty, Kleurenprofiel (Jung), Competency Check
V	Retaining and applying knowledge Knows the rules of the own field by heart and applies them without reference material in varying situations.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Ability Scan, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
K	GDPR and privacy in practice Judges in own processes whether a legal basis exists, applies data minimisation and handles requests from data subjects correctly.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Information management and archiving Independently assesses retention periods for a case file, arranges findability and carries out destruction demonstrably.	 N3	3	no	Kennistoets	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef
T	Spreadsheets and worksheets Enters data in an existing worksheet and uses simple formulas such as sum and average as instructed.	 N2	3	no	Werkproef	Kennistoets (klantspecifiek), Werkproef

T	Skill	Target level	Weight	Knockout	Assessment method	hrmforce instrument
V	Financial administration Posts purchase invoices to the correct ledger account under supervision and refers unclear items to the accountant.	 N2	3	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)
V	Managing service levels and performance indicators Reads the performance overview and reports which agreement was not met in the past week.	 N2	2	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Competency Check
V	Prompting and task delegation to AI Gives an AI tool a single task with a clear question and required format and uses the result after checking it.	 N2	1	no	Werkproef	Werkproef, Portfolio

3 Levels per seniority

The same profile with the job family seniority adjustment applied. Target levels are clamped to 1 to 5.

Skill	junior	medior	senior
Client focus	N3	N4	N5
Accuracy and attention to detail	N2	N3	N4
Working with digital devices and applications	N2	N3	N4
Time management and prioritising	N4	N4	N4
Word processing and document management	N4	N4	N4
Dutch language proficiency at professional level	N2	N3	N4
Complaint handling	N2	N3	N4
Service calls and telephone contact	N2	N3	N4
Written client communication	N2	N3	N4
Stress tolerance	N2	N3	N4
Information gathering and filtering	N2	N3	N4
Correspondence and record keeping	N2	N3	N4
Expectation management	N2	N3	N4
de-escalating and setting limits	N2	N3	N4
Switching between tasks and roles	N2	N3	N4
Retaining and applying knowledge	N2	N3	N4
GDPR and privacy in practice	N2	N3	N4
Information management and archiving	N2	N3	N4
Spreadsheets and worksheets	N1	N2	N3
Financial administration	N1	N2	N3
Managing service levels and performance indicators	N1	N2	N3
Prompting and task delegation to AI	N1	N2	N3

4 The proficiency scale

Level	Label	Autonomy	Complexity	Scope	Depth of knowledge
N1	Guided	works under supervision and follows instruction	routine, one variable at a time	own task	basic understanding of terminology
N2	Applying	works independently within set frameworks	familiar situations with limited variation	own role	working knowledge, applies standard approach
N3	Proficient	sets own approach and seeks input proactively	several variables, some ambiguity	own team or process	thorough knowledge, weighs alternatives
N4	Advanced	directs others and decides on the approach	complex, with conflicting interests	several teams or a department	in-depth knowledge, advises others
N5	Leading	sets the standard and the policy	strategic, under high uncertainty	organisation, value chain or profession	authority, advances the profession

5 Behavioural anchors per skill

Anchors sit at N1, N3 and N5. N2 and N4 are deliberately not anchored: raters interpolate between them, following the O*NET convention.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Client focus Acting from the question and interest of the client, keeping agreements and visibly directing own work towards usefulness for that client.	Responds to client questions within the agreed term and refers on when the answer falls outside own task.	Uncovers the real need behind a client question, makes a fitting proposal and checks after delivery whether it works.	Translates client signals into changes in services and policy and holds the organisation accountable for the promised client experience.
Accuracy and attention to detail Works carefully, checks own work for errors and keeps to agreements about completeness and correctness of data.	Goes through the own work with a checklist and repairs errors found before the work is passed on.	Builds check moments into the own process, keeps track of errors and prevents repetition by adjusting the method.	Sets the standards for completeness and correctness, has samples checked and addresses teams on structural sloppiness.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Working with digital devices and applications Uses computers, mobile devices and standard applications to carry out work tasks, adjusts settings and resolves simple usage problems without help.	Opens and uses the prescribed applications for own tasks and asks for help whenever an unfamiliar message appears.	Selects the appropriate device and application for each task and fixes common disruptions without support from others.	Defines organisation wide which digital workplace facilities are used and guides their introduction across all teams.
Time management and prioritising Allocates available time across tasks by urgency and importance, sets a sequence and adjusts it when new work arrives during the period.	Follows a task list provided by others and asks which task takes priority whenever new requests arrive.	Ranks own work by urgency and importance, builds in buffer time and explains to others why an item will arrive later.	Sets prioritisation agreements and planning standards across the organisation and decides which work streams receive time and capacity when both are scarce.
Word processing and document management Creates and edits documents in word processing software, applies styles and templates and manages versions and findability of files.	Types and edits text in an existing template and saves the file in the designated location using the agreed name.	Builds documents using styles, references and a table of contents and keeps versions and folder structure orderly for the team.	Designs organisation wide templates and document conventions and decides how documents are recorded and archived.
Dutch language proficiency at professional level Commanding Dutch in speech and writing at a level of the Common European Framework of Reference that matches the demands of the role.	Handles simple work conversations and reads short instructions at level A2 to B1 of the European reference framework.	Writes and discusses professional documents fluently at level B2 and adapts register to formal and informal situations.	Commands Dutch at level C1 to C2, edits publications written by others and uses professional and legal phrasing precisely.
Complaint handling Receiving a complaint, tracing its cause and reaching a solution that the client accepts and that prevents the error from recurring.	Records a complaint fully in the system, offers an apology and hands the file over according to procedure.	Calms an angry client, separates emotion from facts and offers a solution with a deadline within own mandate.	Handles escalated cases with legal or publicity risk and uses complaint analysis to change processes structurally.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Service calls and telephone contact Handling client contacts by telephone and chat with a fixed structure, controlled questioning and a closing that contains a concrete agreement.	Answers according to the script, registers the question in the system and transfers the caller to the right colleague.	Settles unusual questions within a single call, keeps call time under control and audibly summarises the agreement made.	Designs conversation models and quality standards for the contact centre and reviews recordings to support coaching and system choices.
Written client communication Answering clients in writing by email, chat and letter with a reply that covers the question and prevents follow up questions.	Uses approved reply templates, fills in client details correctly and has doubtful cases checked before sending.	Writes a tailored reply in plain language, explains a rejection and offers an alternative course of action.	Sets the writing tone and reply library for client communication and tests outgoing texts for legal soundness.
Stress tolerance Keeps delivering work of the same quality under time pressure, opposition or unexpected turns and maintains a businesslike tone with others.	Keeps working on the current task as pressure rises and asks the supervisor which task can wait.	Keeps working in a structured way at peak load, keeps agreements with clients clear and flags early which results are at risk.	Keeps the organisation workable in crises, takes decisions under high uncertainty and sets the standard for composed action under pressure.
Information gathering and filtering Searches purposefully for data in several sources, selects what is relevant to the question and leaves other information out.	Looks up the requested data in the designated sources and delivers them in full and with source references.	Chooses sources independently for an open question, filters out duplicate and outdated data and justifies that choice.	Designs the information flows for the whole field, decides which sources are authoritative and cuts redundant reporting.
Correspondence and record keeping Drafting business letters, emails and conversation records and filing them so that the handling remains traceable later for colleagues and regulators.	Sends standard letters from the system, saves attachments in the agreed location and notes the date of dispatch.	Formulates answers to unusual questions independently, records the considerations briefly and keeps the file complete and up to date.	Designs the correspondence and archiving standard for the organisation, checks compliance and accounts for file quality during an external audit.
Expectation management Making clear in advance what the client will and will not get and when, and reporting in time as soon as that promise becomes unrealistic.	States the delivery time and conditions as recorded and reports any delay immediately to own manager.	Records at the start what falls outside the assignment and discusses deviations with the client before they become visible.	Sets service level agreements for the organisation, weighs feasibility against commercial interest and accounts for deviations to major clients.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
de-escalating and setting limits Reducing rising tension or unwanted behaviour by staying calm, stating the limit clearly and steering or ending the conversation.	Stays calm when facing an angry reaction, lets the other person speak and calls in a colleague or manager.	States which limit is being crossed when behaviour is unwanted, what the consequence is, and ends the conversation when needed.	Establishes organisation-wide agreements on transgressive behaviour, arranges support and follow-up, and holds managers to that line.
Switching between tasks and roles Alternates between tasks, roles and counterparts within a working day and matches content, tone and pace to the situation at hand.	Switches task when instructed and uses the given work instruction per task without mixing in the previous task.	Switches independently between execution and consultation tasks, keeps notes per role and correctly resumes interrupted work.	Fills roles in several bodies with clashing interests at the same time and keeps role clarity visible for the organisation.
Retaining and applying knowledge Keeps acquired professional knowledge available, retrieves the right rule or procedure at the moment it is needed and applies it correctly at work.	Looks up the required procedure in the manual and follows it step by step on a familiar task.	Knows the rules of the own field by heart and applies them without reference material in varying situations.	Oversees the knowledge base of the whole domain, decides which knowledge must be secured and documents it for the organisation.
GDPR and privacy in practice Knows privacy legislation requirements for own work, which legal basis and retention period apply and recognises when notification is required.	Processes personal data only according to the applicable work instruction and refers doubtful cases to the privacy officer.	Judges in own processes whether a legal basis exists, applies data minimisation and handles requests from data subjects correctly.	Sets privacy policy, decides on high risk processing operations and represents the organisation towards the supervisory authority.
Information management and archiving Manages documents and data according to archiving and retention rules, makes information findable and accounts for destruction and transfer.	Registers documents in the case system according to the metadata rules and reports items whose classification is unclear.	Independently assesses retention periods for a case file, arranges findability and carries out destruction demonstrably.	Sets the organisation's information policy and retention schedule and accounts for compliance to the archive inspectorate.
Spreadsheets and worksheets Builds worksheets with formulas, references and pivot tables, checks outcomes and presents figures understandably in tables and charts.	Enters data in an existing worksheet and uses simple formulas such as sum and average as instructed.	Builds a worksheet with linked formulas and pivot tables, checks for errors and explains the calculation logic to colleagues.	Sets the standards for calculation models in the organisation and judges whether models are reliable enough for decision making.

Skill	N1	N3	N5
Financial administration Processes purchase, sales and bank entries in the accounting system, reconciles ledger accounts and delivers an auditable administration.	Posts purchase invoices to the correct ledger account under supervision and refers unclear items to the accountant.	Independently closes the monthly administration, explains differences between subledger and general ledger and corrects incorrect entries.	Designs the layout of the administration and the chart of accounts and sets guidelines for processing and control.
Managing service levels and performance indicators Agrees measurable service and performance standards, measures the actual results and takes action when agreed levels are not met.	Reads the performance overview and reports which agreement was not met in the past week.	Draws up indicators and standards for a service, reports per period and carries out improvement actions on deviation.	Determines the system of service levels for the organisation and negotiates these with customers and suppliers.
Prompting and task delegation to AI Divides work between person and AI system, formulates task, context and required output format and adjusts based on the output.	Gives an AI tool a single task with a clear question and required format and uses the result after checking it.	Splits a work task into steps, decides which step AI does and which not and improves the instruction based on outcomes.	Develops organisation wide practices for dividing tasks with AI and trains others in effective and responsible instruction giving.

6 Assessment methods and validity

The validities are the corrected meta-analytic estimates from Sackett, Zhang, Berry and Lievens (2022) in the Journal of Applied Psychology, which replace the older Schmidt and Hunter (1998) figures. The spread matters as much as the mean: with a high SD, validity varies strongly by context.

Assessment method	rho	SD	What it is
360 feedback	-	-	Multiple raters around the person rate behaviour against behavioural anchors.
Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst	0.21	0.15	Self-report of behavioural preferences. At hrmforce the Big Fifty and the 15PF.
Werkproef	0.33	0.09	The candidate performs a representative work sample under standardised conditions.
Kennistoets	0.40	0.13	Test of declarative job knowledge, usually assembled per client.
Situational Judgement Test	0.12	0.11	Scenario with response options, scored on knowledge or behavioural tendency.
Structureerd interview	0.42	0.19	Behaviour-based interview with fixed questions and a rating scale per question.
Praktijkobservatie	-	-	Structured workplace observation with a form based on behavioural anchors.

7 Assessment instruments for this job

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Werkproef	12	Representatief werkfragment onder gestandaardiseerde condities
Kennistoets (klantspecifiek)	8	Toets van vakkennis, per klant samengesteld
Competency Check	6	Competentiebeoordeling op gedragsniveau
Big Fifty	5	Persoonlijkheidsvragenlijst, 150 items, 25 factoren
360 Feedback	3	Meervoudige beoordeling op gedragsankers
Conflictstijlen	2	Voorkeursstijl in conflictsituaties
Mentale Weerbaarheid (4C)	2	Mentale weerbaarheid volgens het 4C-model
Communicatiestijlen	1	Voorkeursstijl in communicatie
15PF	1	Persoonlijkheidsprofiel, korter alternatief voor de Big Fifty

hrmforce instrument	Skills	What it measures
Structureerd interview	1	Gedragsggericht interview met vaste opzet
Kleurenprofiel (Jung)	1	Vier kleurentypen, gekoppeld aan Big Fifty-factoren
Ability Scan	1	Capaciteitentest: verbaal, numeriek en abstract redeneervermogen
Portfolio	1	Beoordeling van eerder werk tegen vaste criteria

8 How to use this profile

1. Agree the profile with the hiring manager before the first candidate is measured. Weights shifted afterwards make the outcome indefensible.
2. Choose the assessment method per skill from the Assessment method column. Combine at most three methods per candidate.
3. Calibrate the assessors in a two-hour session using the anchors in chapter 5. Anchors without rater training deliver little.
4. Fill in the match calculator and discuss the gaps in the development conversation. Type A and type G are selection criteria, not one-quarter development goals.

Source: hrmforce Skills Framework 2.0, version 2.0.0, built 2026-09-08. Crosswalks to ESCO v1.2.1, O*NET 31.0, Lightcast Open Skills, SFIA 9, DigComp 3.0, EntreComp, LifeComp, GreenComp, Allit, WEF Future of Jobs 2025, ISCO-08 and the Dutch CBS occupational classification BRC 2014 edition 2025. This profile is a starting point, not a standard: align it with your own organisation before selecting on it.